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UG Madness: Matchup Analysis vs. RG Beats

Jeff Cunningham

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Part 1: New Beginnings (Prologue)

It's time for another frank discussion about U/G Madness.

Here was the build I used to play against Justin Gary. Since I was getting reports from just about everyone that R/G's the most popular deck, and it beats U/G (Kai declared the matchup to be 70% in favor of R/G,) this list reflects an attempt to streamline the deck, making it as aggressive as possible, as well as making sure it can handle R/G appropriately.

Brainburst Classics



UG Madness V.2

Jeff Cunningham

Format: Type2

»Apprentice Format«

Main Deck

4 Aquamoeba
4 Arrogant Wurm
4 Basking Rootwalla
4 Wild Mongrel
3 Wonder

4 Careful Study
4 Circular Logic
3 Deep Analysis
3 Quiet Speculation
2 Roar of the Wurm
3 Unsummon

1 City of Brass
10 Forest
11 Island

Sideboard

4 Compost
2 Divert
4 Merfolk Looter
2 Ray of Revelation
1 Roar of the Wurm
2 Turbulent Dreams

Total deck value: \$125.25

BUY THIS DECK

Notes:

Average Casting Cost (ACC)= 2.57

Spells by Color:

Cards by Type:

*Hover mouse cursor over pie chart to see ==>> COLOR/TYPE : # CARDS : % OF CARDS.

*Left click on pie chart or legend to isolate a field.

The sophisticated reader will notice three significant changes from my first build several months ago. I'll outline them.

1. The Unsummons Three

When Kai declared the 70% statistic, the most startling thing about it was that it was accurate. Without the necessary tools in this matchup, the U/G player is a sitting duck. Aquamoebas instead of Merfolk Looters are critical in this matchup. This deck has them. Quiet Speculation is a backbreaking force, giving the U/G player the game in a stalemate. Finally, there's Unsummon. This handles everything else. It maintains early game tempo, screws up combat math, and makes their Elephant Guides into huge liabilities. This deck has them. If you want to be able to handle R/G with U/G, this is your build.

Also worth mentioning is Unsummon over Aether Burst. Unsummon is strictly better in this deck, in my opinion, and here's why: mana curve. This deck's core engine is based on two mana spells: Wild Mongrel, Aquamoeba, Quiet Speculation, Deep Analysis (Flashback)... why add more of them? Unsummon's single mana cost is hugely relevant... it fills the cracks of your mana curve. I often used it at the end of my opponent's turn when I was drawing first to return their Wild Mongrel to gain tempo, or during my third turn after playing a Madness outlet. Bounce is definitely a handy ability, but it's usefulness hinges on being able to use it without setting yourself back too much. Leaving up a single mana is rarely an issue.

2. Looting ("For Value" - Ken Krouner)

Added four Merfolk Looters to the Sideboard for the mirror match. Equilibrium, Callous Oppressor, Spellbane Centaur, and Aether Burst are all cards that people recommended to bring in, but the fact is, which I can attest to after many many playtest hours with this deck, the best card in the mirror is Merfolk Looter. It's better than Wild Mongrel. In almost every other matchup, Aquamoeba is strictly superior, but in this one, it's very important to have access to it after sideboard. Handle their Equilibrium's with your Ray. Handle their Callous Oppressor with Unsummon, or by naming Wurm. Don't bring in too many blue targeted spells, and Spellbane won't be an issue. Keep it simple.

3. Cuts

To make room for the 3 Unsummons, I removed an Island, a Ray of Revelation, and a Roar of the Wurm. In Extended I played with only 22 lands and it worked fine, so I thought I would try it like that again... and there was no issue. With so many early drops and Deep Analysis, 22 is a fair number. Removing the Ray hurt, and I'm still torn... the problem is that Game 1 there's only one deck you really want it against - Slide. However, in that matchup it's critical. I waver back and forth on this issue, but at the time of the match against Justin, I was leaning towards cutting it.

Cutting the third Roar was another thing I had done in Extended, which worked fine. Some people consider four to be necessary. This is ridiculous. Don't get me wrong, it's a great card, but I never ran out versus Justin. I never needed more than the two I would often fetch with Speculation. Sure, sometimes it's nice not to have to waste the mana to Quiet Speculation, and that happens often enough, but I find two to be a perfectly legitimate number maindeck, since I would often board the third out in several matchups anyway. The third is in the sideboard, for the matchups in which it's good (like this one). The games I would lose to R/G would not really be the result of not enough Roars, though. The games I lost to R/G were because of two things and two things only: manascrew, and Ensnaring Bridge.

I made some changes to the list after playing our games, so I'll post that after. Throughout the article I'll also

get to some of the criticisms of the deck from message board yahoos, pro yahoos, and all-around yahoos (Zvi).
(Affectionately speaking, of course.)

Part 2: First Half (A Blowout)

RG Beats

Kai Budde

Format: Type2

»Apprentice Format«

Courtesy of our friends at Sideboard

Main Deck

4 Basking Rootwalla
4 Grim Lavamancer
4 Llanowar Elves
2 Skirk Marauder
4 Wild Mongrel

4 Call of the Herd
4 Elephant Guide
4 Firebolt
4 Violent Eruption
4 Volcanic Hammer

2 Barbarian Ring
6 Forest
4 Karplusan Forest
2 Mossfire Valley
4 Mountain
4 Wooded Foothills

Sideboard

3 Caller of the Claw
4 Compost
4 Ensnaring Bridge
2 Naturalize
2 Phantom Centaur

Total deck value: \$289.5

BUY THIS DECK

Notes:

Average Casting Cost (ACC)= 2.21	
Spells by Color:	Cards by Type:
*Hover mouse cursor over pie chart to see ==>> COLOR/TYPE : # CARDS : % OF CARDS. *Left click on pie chart or legend to isolate a field.	

I lost two games to mana troubles, one game to a mistake on my part, and won the other seven.

Game 1:

Justin's draw is a little sub par, he plays a turn 1 Lavamancer, but has nothing on turn 2. Turn 3 he drops an Elephant Guide on it, but even though he's on the play, it's not enough. You know, Wurms. That old walnut.

In the R/G vs U/G matchup, if either play has a draw that is not completely up to snuff, the game's usually over pretty quickly.

An important part of this matchup is knowing when to race your opponent and knowing when to grind them. U/G can play both games, depending on the situation. If you have a Wonder in the graveyard, you usually want to end the game as quickly as possible. Do the math, attack, and chump block if necessary. If you don't have Wonder, or they come out too quick, then the trick is just to keep sponging up their creatures and burn with creatures of your own. When the game goes long, the card advantage you'll get from your Deep Analysis' and Quiet Speculations will push you way over the top, so you just have to make sure you get to that point.

1-0

Game 2:

I mulligan, and don't do anything but Speculate into both Roars and a Deep Analysis. To make matters worse I don't make my fourth land drop until it's much too late.

Though if I had hit my fourth land I might've had a shot, the lesson's an important one: don't rely on Quiet Speculation. It should be the last card out of your hand, not the first one. Ideally, you just want to trade creatures until both players' hands are exhausted, and then drop it. At that point, it's devastating. It usually won't win the game on its own, though, so don't try to make it.

1-1

Game 3:

He gets the "nut draw." Mongrels. Violent Eruption. Elephant Guide. Support.

However, my draw is no slouch either... by blocking carefully and making sure to never get wrecked by Violent Eruption, I just follow my plan and sponge up the beats. Unsummon ruins his Guide, I Spec, and that's that.

2-1

Game 4:

I Careful Study through two Deep Analysis', and since I'm on the play, I have time to flash them back. Being on the play in this matchup is important for two reasons:

1. You can Deep Analysis on the second turn without falling behind in the tempo race. This allows your Mongrels to be much bigger (and better) than theirs.
2. You can actually keep a Mongrel on the board until your third turn to drop an Arrogant Wurm... they have to choose between dropping a creature and burning your Mongrel, usually opting for the former.

I keep an almost full hand most of the game, and bully him with my creatures.

3-1

Game 5:

More of the same. My Mongrel takes the burn like a lightning rod, and I'm able to stay high on life. This allows me to milk my Deeps, and let the card advantage from Quiet Speculation break his back.

4-1

Game 6:

I double mulligan into a hand that's decent if my Mongrel can live one turn. It can't.

Mongrel down!! I repeat, Mongrel down!!!!

Oh, God!!!

4-2

There are essentially three kinds of manascrew. Not drawing enough lands to function, drawing too many lands to function, and not drawing the correct color of land. This deck, with its low land count and cheap spells, is above average at dealing with the first two, but has trouble with the third. Unlike the R/G deck, for example, U/G doesn't have access to fetch lands or pain lands.

So why don't I play more than one City of Brass? This deck, one of the most efficient in recent memory, has a very low land count. Every land you get is being used almost every turn for the rest of the game. City of Brass hurts in this deck, perhaps more than in any other.

Life is a critical resource. Your life is equal to additional cards from Deep Analysis which is equal to additional damage to your opponent through Wild Mongrel. This deck can run perfectly as long as it gets one Forest and one Island. It's not that unlikely. The color balance is almost equal in the deck, so it's no problem to play almost an equal amount of each color. Drawing one City of Brass puts you at a serious disadvantage, drawing two is game losing. I would honestly rather risk color screw almost all of the time.

As long as you have blue mana even, you have access to Careful Study and Deep Analysis. I think one City of Brass is the right number, I run it to balance the mana ratio of the deck appropriately.

Game 7:

I never draw a madness outlet this game, but he can't get through my creatures that are naturally bigger than his.

5-2

Game 8:

Mongrel, Arrogant Wurm, Roar on the play.

6-2

Game 9:

Here's the game I should have won, but lost. I took pretty detailed notes for this one, so I can cover the important decisions.

I'm drawing, which is definitely a considerable disadvantage in this matchup, but my opening hand is good, I have: Aquamoeba, Aquamoeba, Wild Mongrel, Circular Logic, Quiet Speculation, Island, and Forest. To complement this my first two draws are Wonder, and Forest... pretty much exactly what I want.

Justin has no first turn play, but lays a Mongrel on turn two.

On my second turn, I can either play the Aquamoeba or the Wild Mongrel. Wild Mongrel's more resilient, not dying to Volcanic Hammer, but if I play Aquamoeba, I'll be able to play Wild Mongrel and have Logic mana up on the third turn. That play seems better, so I lay down the Aquamoeba.

He attacks on the following turn, putting me at 18, and the race is on. He doesn't play a third land, but plays another Mongrel. Missing land drops in this matchup is very bad. At this point, mainly because of the Wonder in my hand, I'm almost already counting this as a win.

On my turn, I untap, discard the Wonder, and hit Justin down to seventeen. I play a Wild Mongrel, leaving Logic mana up, and pass the turn. On his turn, he attacks me back, and I take the damage. With Wonder in the yard, and him stuck on two land, this seems like the play. He doesn't play a third land yet again, and passes the turn.

Here is where I make my critical error... A really poor judgment call. I can only really blame it on playing too fast on Apprentice. Instead of playing the Wild Mongrel, leaving Logic mana open, and continuing to race, I get too greedy. I flash back the Analysis, since he's stuck on two land and I want to get a leg up, and plan to draw my fourth land, play another Mongrel, and be so far ahead that I almost guarantee myself the game... having enough damage to kill him on the next attack, and giving myself a chump blocker if necessary. Unfortunately, I don't draw the fourth land. I have to pass the turn, with no blue mana up! If I had just played the Mongrel and Deep Analysis'd next turn, I would've guaranteed myself the win... having a Logic in case he draws his third land and plays the only card that can get him back in the game... Elephant Guide. And he does.

Eventually, the game comes down to several turns in a row where I can win if I draw either an Unsummon or my second Island so that I can Quiet Speculation for Deep Analysis and kill him with Mongrel in the same turn, but I don't.

The lesson here: When you're winning, press the advantage. R/G's very good at coming back.

6-3

Game 10:

Wonder allows me to race the way I want to, and my hand's good enough that he can't do anything about it.

Zvi said that Wonder wasn't very important in this matchup, and I must say, I disagree quite strongly. Often, without it, they can chump block your Wurms long enough to kill you with Lavamancer and the extra burn they'll draw. Wonder allows you to control the pace of the game completely, and that's a huge advantage. That said, I still wouldn't advocate playing four. Drawing two, or even three over the course of the game is a bad thing. This is perhaps the best example of a card you want to draw one of, and only one of. Against Tog, the game will usually go long enough that you can draw into it naturally.

7-3

The game one matchup versus Red/Green with this deck is fantastic, and the results of these ten games is representative. Expect to win 65-70%.

Part 3: Second Half (A Rude Awakening)

I sideboard in 1 Roar of the Wurm, 2 Divert and 2 Turbulent Dreams, and take out 4 Circular Logics and a Deep Analysis.

Justin was worried about Unsummon and sideboarded out Guides. After a bit of thought, I agree with this move since U/G is also likely bringing in Turbulent Dreams.

Game 1:

I'm on the play, so my Mongrel sticks. I get a good draw, a Wonder, Divert his Volcanic Hammer at his Rootwalla, and it seems over. Then he drops Bridge. I have about ten turns to find a Turbulent Dreams (Deep Analysis, and Unsummon won't do it) but don't.

I had theorized that only 2 Turbulent Dreams would be needed since you could also either Unsummon their creatures to get additional damage through, or Deep Analysis' them... but those are very unreliable routes. After sideboard, it almost always comes down to whether or not you have the answer for the Bridge. The next nine games, for the most part, would just be a lesson in that.

0-1

Game 2:

I double mulligan. He Bridges me.

0-2

Game 3:

I mulligan. He bridges me.

0-3

Game 4:

I mulligan and my draw can't handle his.

0-4

Game 5:

The one time I *do* have the Dreams in hand and a decent draw, he doesn't even draw his Bridge.

1-4

Game 6:

He draws bridge, I don't draw Dreams.

(Pretty simple, isn't it?)

The reason the post-sideboarded games are so cut and dried compared to the pre-sideboarded games is that to make room for their Bridges, they have to take a lot of the oomph out of their deck. They can almost never beat you without Bridge because of this. They do their early damage, lay Bridge, and take two to at most eight or nine turns to burn you out. If you have a Bridge answer, you're almost always good to go.

Even so, however, I think it's important to have Turbulent Dreams instead of Naturalize... it's great insurance against Elephant Guide, and helps make sure that you're not diluting your deck the way they are.

1-5

Game 7:

I draw the nuts. He draws no Bridge.

2-5

Game 8:

He draws Bridge. I draw Dreams.

3-5

Game 9:

He draws Bridge. I don't draw Dreams.

3-6

Game 10: He draws Bridge. I draw Dreams.

4-6

I think if I had sideboarded correctly, or had more passable draws earlier in the matchup, the game score would have been a lot more accurate. Divert's useless, especially if your opponent knows about it, as Justin did. The matchup doesn't revolve around creature racing anymore - they concede that to you after they board in their Bridges. It's about whether or not you can handle the Bridge when the time comes. Circular Logic's not reliable... Justin could sneak the Bridge out at almost any point in the game and have it be effective, and I'm bound to tap out of blue mana sometime. It comes down to being able to take the Bridge off the board. Three Turbulent Dreams should be enough to reliably be able to do it when the time comes. The third Roar comes in because it forces them to win via Bridge.

Some people still board Threaten in R/G... though I don't think it's the best way. If you know your opponent is boarding this way, you can leave the Dreams in the sideboard.

After sideboard, I'd say this build is looking at least a 55% shot of beating R/G.

(Total 11-9)

The first game matchup added to post sideboarded matchup equals a very good matchup for this build of U/G madness.

Part 4: End Game (Epilogue)

This is the version of U/G Madness that I consider to be the best build for Regionals.

The Real Regionals U/G

Jeff Cunningham

Format: Type2

»Apprentice Format«

Main Deck

Sideboard

4 Aquamoeba
 4 Arrogant Wurm
 4 Basking Rootwalla
 4 Wild Mongrel
 3 Wonder

4 Careful Study
 4 Circular Logic
 3 Deep Analysis
 3 Quiet Speculation
 1 Ray of Revelation
 2 Roar of the Wurm
 2 Unsummon

1 City of Brass
 10 Forest
 11 Island

3 Compost
 2 Gigapede
 4 Merfolk Looter
 1 Ray of Revelation
 1 Roar of the Wurm
 3 Turbulent Dreams
 1 Unsummon

Total deck value: \$126.5

BUY THIS DECK

Notes:

Average Casting Cost (ACC)= 2.72	
Spells by Color:	Cards by Type:
*Hover mouse cursor over pie chart to see ==>> COLOR/TYPE : # CARDS : % OF CARDS. *Left click on pie chart or legend to isolate a field.	

I'll admit it, Zvi. Gigapede's nice. Other than that, though, I think the build missed the boat. Equilibrium is most certainly not enough to handle Ensnaring Bridge, and it's not the kind of card that's even good in the R/G matchup post-sideboard, which is what I am covering with this build. Merfolk Looter IS good in the U/G mirror match, and it's worth boarding. Four Wonder and Four Roars are unnecessary in this version, and take up spots better served by other cards.

In all of my playtesting, I have not found a single bad matchup for this version of U/G. I consider it to far and away be the best choice for the current T2 environment.

Good luck at Regionals everyone.

- Jeff Cunningham
 ffejontheirc@yahoo.com

[Editor's note - Here are Jeff's follow up answers to his article, which were only available within the Premium Forums. It is a great example of the kind of feedback you can expect. - Ray]

ffeJ Premium Writer  2004 Posts	Posted - 04/19/2003 : 06:57:55     
Hey Boys, 1. Turbulent Dreams > Boomerang in case they get out 2 bridges. :) Happens. That said, I wouldn't call	

you crazy if you played Boomerang instead.

2. To the person that asked why U/G madness changes so much over the course of ten days. My response: It doesn't. Mine certainly doesn't. This build's stayed within 2-3 maindeck cards of the version it was a month and a half ago. SB changes to accomodate metagame.

3. Compost is too good not to play, and without it beating MBC is an extremely difficult matchup.

I had intended to include a SB'ing guide with the deck, so here it is. A little something I like to call....

Sideboarding with U/G Madness

Psychatog

-1 Ray of Revelation
 -3 Arrogant Wurm
 -2 Circular Logic
 +1 Roar of the Wurm
 +3 Compost
 +2 Gigapede

R/G

-1 Ray of Revelation
 -3 Circular Logic
 +3 Turbulent Dreams
 +1 Unsummon

U/G Mirror

-4 Aquamoeba
 -1 Quiet Speculation
 +4 Merfolk Looter
 +1 Unsummon

Slide

-1 Deep Analysis
 +1 Ray of Revelation

W/G

-4 Aquamoeba
 -1 Deep Analysis
 -1 Quiet Speculation
 +4 Merfolk Looter
 +1 Unsummon
 +1 Roar of the Wurm

Wake

Nada.

MBC

-1 Ray of Revelation
 -3 Wonder
 +3 Compost
 +1 Roar of the Wurm

Does MBC bring in bridge? If so, unfortunately, you have to bring in the Dreams. At least 2, probably all 3. The unsummons are much better because they're a cheap way to reuse Mongrels etc, but they could go out for the Dreams if need be.

Goblins
 -1 Deep Analysis
 -4 Circular Logic
 +3 Turbulent Dreams
 +1 Roar of the Wurm
 +1 Unsummon

Thanks guys,

Jeff

[Editor's note: If you liked this article by Jeff, be sure to check out his other great articles. - Ray]

Title	Writer	Date	Article Type
UG Madness: Matchup Analysis vs. RG Beats	Jeff Cunningham	4/18/2003	Strategy: Type II
Pro Tour Venice: This Is Awkward (55th)	Jeff Cunningham	4/8/2003	Strategy: OnBC
UG Madness: Matchup Analysis vs. Astral Slide	Jeff Cunningham	3/7/2003	Strategy: Type II
The Magic Colony: <i>Secrets</i>	Jeff Cunningham	2/19/2003	Behind the Scenes
Chicago '03: <i>Finding 0-4ester</i>	Jeff Cunningham	1/28/2003	Report: Onslaught Limited
PT Chicago Report Part 1: <i>My Masters Diary</i>	Jeff Cunningham	1/23/2003	Strategy: Type II (11/02-2/03)
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